

Website Redesign

Upstate Underdog Rescue

Star Olaojo, CJ Marino, Ben Froling, Jacob Hebbel, Alan Aguilera

Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute

COMM-4420

Dr. Justin Dowdall

Contents

Upstate Underdog Rescue.....	0
Contents.....	1
Executive Summary.....	2
Introduction.....	3
Problem Statement.....	3
Research Methods.....	5
Approach & Methodologies.....	5
Discover.....	7
Define.....	9
Design Artifacts.....	10
Develop.....	13
Deliver.....	17
Results.....	xx
Research Conclusions.....	xx
Site Walkthrough.....	xx
Home Page.....	xx
About.....	xx
Adopt.....	xx
Donate.....	xx

Executive Summary

Over the last 12 weeks, Upstate Underdog Rescue (UUR) has been studied by select students (hereafter ‘the team’) in COMM-4420 Foundations of HCI Usability. This course develops skills to analytically describe design choices using empirical methods backed by science. By following carefully constructed *research methods*, the ways users interact (UI) and experience (UX) a product can be measured and improved, generating value for UUR.

Over the last 12 weeks, the team proposed and acted upon a set of research methods chosen uniquely for UUR’s position and objectives. The purpose of these methods is to iteratively collect and aggregate information into concepts, such as key questions or features. The term for this framework is the “Double Diamond”, a common industry standard.

The results of these studies show that the current UUR site struggles in several key areas: site layout, buried information, and unfinished features. This creates a misalignment between the action and intent of the site, resulting in missed opportunities for user-client interactions that would benefit UUR.

After analyzing the results of these studies, the team proposes several changes to the UUR site that focus on simple features with high impact. These changes promote the superhero branding and empathy-first philosophy of UUR while addressing the aforementioned struggle areas. .

The team implemented their vision within a Weebly website. This matches the environment of the old site, enabling a simple migration. The deployment plan would have an annual cost of 13\$ / month, or 100\$ / year.

Introduction

Abstract

In the Digital Age, the website is a critical piece of infrastructure for small businesses. They are cheap, highly versatile, and integrable with a variety of services . However, designing an effective website that conveys an organization's goals and targets key clients is difficult. Research in design thinking has proposed several methodologies to solve this. Through the execution of targeted studies, design 'truths' can be learned in an empirically-backed fashion. In this paper, the team follows these UI / UX research methods to discover improvements to UUR's with a series of tailored research studies.

Problem Statement

The major issue Upstate Underdog Rescue faces is finding quality people to house dogs. This process involves analysis of qualitative data (forms), client (user) interviews, and meet-and-greets with potential dogs. While laborious, this process is necessary to ensure the dog's home is permanent. But by redesigning the website with design theory, the cognitive load of this process can be mitigated while promoting the UUR brand.

First, the website should support this process by disseminating information about the dogs, the adoption process, and who should consider rescuing a dog. The website should act as a screening tool that ensures invested clients initiate the adoption process. This would alleviate a significant amount of cognitive load on the business. However, the site should not drive away

non-target clients, as that would deny their potential to bring value. The conundrum is then to derive value from the entire user base when a majority may not qualify as adopters.

The current site implements strategies to achieve this goal with mixed results. The primary attention hook, the dogs, are present but not immediately present. The screening method is a long survey necessary to be completed before the adoption process continues. This workflow favors commitment and engagement to the task without judging the user. However, commitment may not imply quality, and therefore, an amount of review is required by the company. Other secondary methods for deriving value include a volunteering section and donate/shop page, but a client interview from October suggests these features produce marginal value. In general, the site addresses the problem statement, but its features are implemented in a naive fashion that leaves room for improvement.

To improve the Upstate Underdog Rescue website, the team must reimagine solutions to these features while preserving their branding. To do so, the team proposes a design study composed of several research methods. By executing each, the team gains more insight into the identity of UUR, the effectiveness of their features, and how to develop tailored solutions. With the knowledge these methods will bring, the team can propose data-driven design choices that will improve UUR's ability to achieve its goals.

Research Methods

Approach & Methodologies

The team will employ a mixed-methods research design to build a holistic understanding of the user experience when interacting with UUR by following the Double Diamond approach.

The team will organize the research methods to meet the staged goals of this framework, enabling design decisions that are directly informed by the UUR brand.

The Double Diamond was developed by the British Design Council in 2005 as a thought process for developing sensible products. The framework can be envisioned as a double diamond, where the four stages alternate between acquiring information and condensing it into artifacts, which are documents that support design decisions.

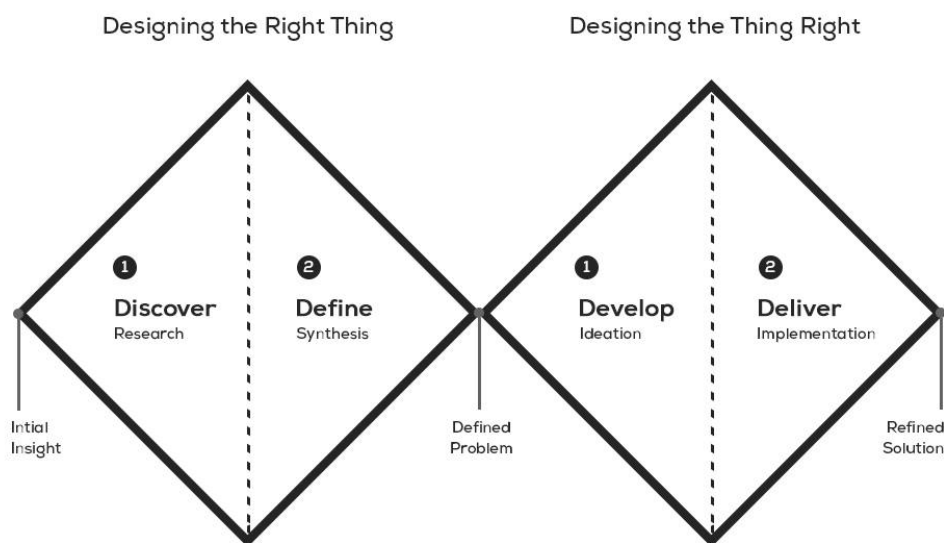


Figure 1: The Double Diamond. Its geometric intuition states information must be collected and aggregated before reaching a well-formed idea

The British Design Council adds a level of granularity to this concept by labeling each area. The four stages refer to intermittent stages in the design process.

Discover refers to the process of building a knowledge base about the product. To accomplish this, the team developed a set of User Personas and User Stories. These studies build a mental model of the user to understand what an intuitive interface means to them.

Stage 2, Define, condenses the knowledge domain into driving questions: what is useful, what is natural, and what is missing? The team implemented Card Sorting and a Comparative Analysis to apply the mental models from Stage 1 to the UUR organization and a competitor, Every Last One. The outcome was vital. By assuming a correct mental model, the team identified differences between these two products and built a collection of features and concepts that define the user experience.

The Develop stage once again opens the knowledge domain. In the context of site features, the team built pages from this knowledge. Additionally, a client interview was conducted with Mariesa, founder of UUR. This interview opened the domain by adding a new perspective: considering utility features that are organization-facing.

The Deliver phase focused on evaluating the effectiveness of the redesigned website through empirical testing rather than producing additional features. To validate design choices, the team conducted A/B testing comparing the redesigned website (Diamonds) against the original site (Hearts). Evaluation methods included AI-assisted sentiment analysis, quantitative usability ratings using 5-point Likert scales, task-based usability testing, and qualitative thematic analysis of open-ended responses. Together, these methods provided both quantitative and qualitative evidence to assess usability, trustworthiness, and donation intent. The results of these

evaluations served as research deliverables, enabling the team to determine where the redesign improved user experience and where further refinement may be needed.

Discover

In the discovery phase, the team focused on developing a comprehensive understanding of the UUR user base by writing user portfolios and user stories. These tools help lay the foundational groundwork for understanding who interacts with UUR, with the goal of building a product that tailors to these users.

When making user portfolios, the team considered two primary users: first-time owners and veteran adopters. The purpose of stories is to learn better predictions of how they interact with a product when considering how their personal experience may play a role. An example of the personas are shown below.

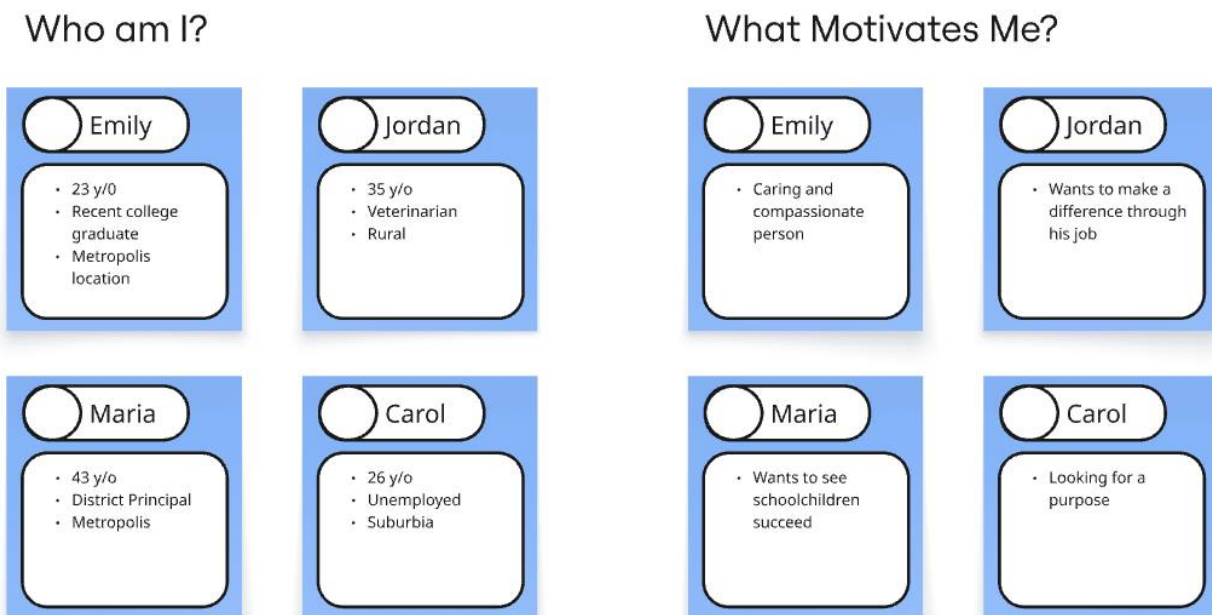


Figure 2: An excerpt from the team's user persona document

The information yielded from user personas leads a design to scaffold around a mentality. By considering how these mentalities may interact with a product the team can build empathy-first features that will feel native to users.

After developing User Portfolios, the team conducted a series of User Stories to produce detailed interaction maps with the product. These User Stories elevate the User Portfolio by applying it directly to the site. Stories consider external factors like predisposition, moral values, and tech familiarity and observe how they impact UX. By building a cohesive mental model of users and using it as design infrastructure, designers can produce empathetic products that feel natural to users. An example of a user story is shown below:

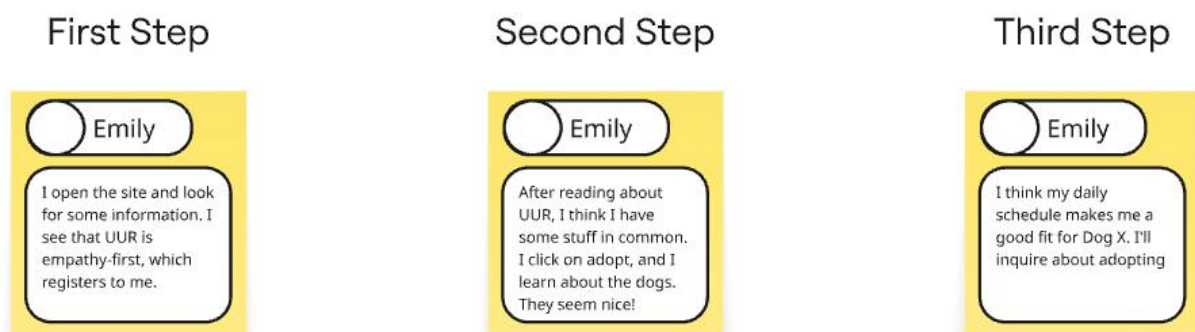


Figure 3: Actions taken by Emily, a potential user

This is the ‘middle’ of the story infographic. The beginning establishes Emily’s mental model, derived from the User Portfolio. The middle shows several actions Emily takes while on the site, and the End observes Emily’s mental state as a result of interacting with the product. By applying this process to the various Users, the team learned several truths about the UX of adoption.

The major observations from this process was a responsibility to inform users whether they would be good candidates to adopt from UUR. Users need to be aware that establishing

successful relationships require patience, empathy, and resilience, but these concepts need to be delivered in a fact-check that users can use to honestly examine themselves.

Define

The team used a Comparative Analysis and Card Sorting to organize user knowledge from discovery into guiding artifacts. These artifacts represent the knowledge base applied to existing products and explain how these products' design choices translate into value. With these artifacts the team had a clear roadmap for planning the new UUR site.

Card Sorting was used to apply the mental models derived from the Discovery phase to the UUR site. Card Sorting involves identifying key phrases and branding about a product as a means to build a strong understanding of what it stands for. Then, these concepts are organized into classes, which produce a mental model of the product.

The identified concepts were related to empathy, kindness, and developing heartfelt connections. The main drivers behind these concepts were due to UUR's humanitarian practices and the heartwarming testimonials delivered by clients. Additionally, a major identified branding point was the 'superhero' concept. This idea packages a dog's unique tendencies (docile lap dog, energetic cheerleader) as superpowers that bond with their owners. This framework also works in the reverse, where a dog's challenges are their 'kryptonite' which repackages the negative connotations in a new way that avoids stereotypes. These concepts were deemed as core design features that supported the whole development process.

Afterwards, the team considered how user mental models aligned with the UUR mental model defined by Card Sorting. By doing so, connections between client and company were observed and identified as key branding positions. Additionally, misalignment between user and

brand were also identified. By considering both, the team's design choices will emphasize existing strong points while supplementing soft spots.

A Comparative Analysis

We conducted a comparative analysis of nonprofit animal rescue websites, including Every Last One Rescue and New Jersey South Hills Pet Rescue, to identify effective design patterns and usability practices. These organizations were selected due to their similar mission, target audience, and reliance on online adoption and donation workflows.

Through this analysis, we evaluated navigation structure, donation visibility, emotional storytelling, visual hierarchy, and trust-building elements. Every Last One Rescue demonstrated strong user engagement through prominent calls to action, emotionally resonant imagery, bright and inviting color usage, and streamlined donation flows. In contrast, New Jersey South Hills Pet Rescue relied more heavily on informational content, with less emphasis on visual engagement and fewer conversion-focused design elements.

An important insight from this comparison was that users were more inclined to adopt from Every Last One Rescue due to its strong visual presentation and emotionally engaging design. This contrast served as an effective high-quality versus low-quality comparator, helping establish a clear benchmark for the level of polish, clarity, and emotional appeal we aimed to achieve in the Upstate Underdog Rescue website.

Beyond visual design, this analysis also informed decisions about content prioritization and site structure. By examining which pages were emphasized across comparable organizations, we identified which pages were most critical to user engagement and conversion. This led to the creation of a structured page template defining essential pages such as the homepage, navigation hierarchy, events page, and donation page. Additionally, insights from competitor sites helped

determine which types of visual imagery were most effective at motivating users to donate and engage with the organization.

These insights directly informed our design decisions, including clearer donation pathways, reduced visual clutter, stronger emotional engagement through imagery and color, simplified user flows, and a strategically organized page hierarchy. Collectively, these changes aim to enhance usability while increasing user trust and donation intent.

Design Artifacts

After building a cohesive understanding of both product and user, the team felt confident in building the first artifacts. The delivered artifacts were website features such as palettes, fonts, and some graphics. Each of these were selected with the knowledge brought from the Discover and Define processes.

The color palette the team selected was influenced by the vibrant themes discovered in Card Sorting. The colors bring out the heartfelt and lively nature of the dogs without becoming exaggerated.



Figure 4: Color Palette for UUR Website Redesign

The new UUR color palette expands and modernizes the previous limited palette of Underdog Blue, White, and Black while keeping the brand's iconic blue at its core. Underdog Blue is paired with Braveheart Blue, a darker yet vibrant shade that reflects the courage of the dogs and volunteers, and complemented by Forever Friend Pink, a warm, inviting color that symbolizes the love for these dogs and their journey to finding a forever home making the name "Forever Friend Pink" a perfect fit. Soft Paws Silver serves as an off-white alternative to brighten designs, while Paw Print Navy replaces black with a fun, bold contrast that ties the palette together. Each color is named to reflect the personality and mission of the organization while providing flexibility for modern, cohesive branding.

The graphic artifacts produced also reinforce the branding decisions identified by the Define process. Two graphics, a background pattern and a pawprint decal, are shown below.

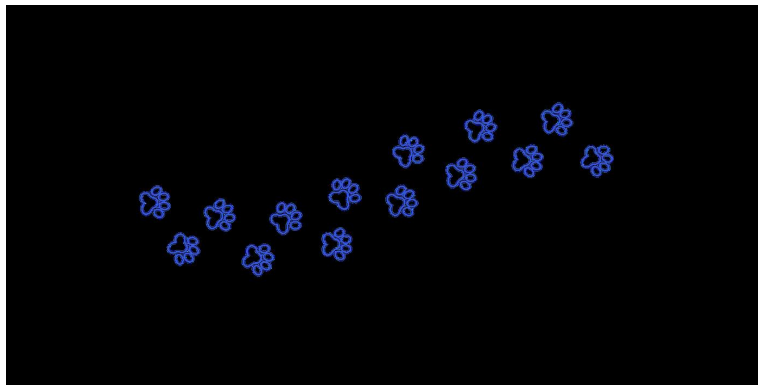


Figure 5: Underdog Paw Print

The Underdog Paw Print graphic was intentionally chosen as a core element of the overall branding because it reinforces the theme connecting superheroes, superpowers, and underdogs. Each rescued dog is seen as a hero with unique strengths, resilience, and heart, and the paw print symbolizes the mark they leave on the world and on the families they transform. The graphic uses Braveheart Blue from the new color palette, a tone selected to reflect the courage and bravery these dogs show as they work toward leaving their mark on their future families. Designed as an outline rather than a filled shape, the paw print allows any text, imagery, or design element placed over it to remain clearly readable, making it both visually meaningful and highly adaptable across all brand applications.



Figure 5: Bone Dog Tag Pattern

The bone dog tag pattern was selected as a defining symbol of the overall branding because it represents each underdog’s “superhero icon,” much like the S is to Superman or the bat symbol is to Batman. For these dogs, the bone-shaped tag signifies their new identity as they move from uncertainty into a life where they are cared for, valued, and truly seen. It reflects the moment they step into their role as a hero within their future family, carrying with them a symbol of love, loyalty, and transformation. The design is intentionally bold yet friendly, allowing it to serve as a recognizable emblem across all brand materials. Its distinctive shape reinforces the message that every adopted dog gains not only a home but a new chapter and a “superhero

identity” defined by trust, protection, and the powerful bond they share with the people who choose them.

Develop

When starting the Develop phase, the team integrated their artifacts with a Founder Interview to explore a wealth of design possibilities. Through this process the team implemented design choices for the site that aim to capture the ideal product for online rescue adoption.

During the team’s Founder Interview, multiple revelatory discussions happened. The team learned the struggles in converting users to adopters. While the site was able to generate interest in UUR, the only adoptions have happened through Founder connections. This brought client conversion to the forefront of design. UUR has had better success at finding adopters at dog shows as compared to over the internet due to the convenience of verification.

Additionally, several features that were left unattended (Shop, Events) in the old site were discussed. The online shop and donation service had seen minimal traffic, likely due to the broken links. This was concerning due to UUR being a small business, and any revenue stream would be invaluable for funding their operation. Their events page was also neglected, as UUR had seen a downturn in events over the last few months. From this discussion, the team decided that revenue streams should be combined into a Donate button, and the events page was redesigned as a lightweight calendar-based page rather than a feature-heavy section. This follows a methodology that emphasizes primary features for a simpler UX.

After the Founder Interview, the team identified these key pages:

- **Home Page**
- **About Page**
- **Donate Page**
- **Adopt Page**

For the homepage, the team made a series of foundational design decisions that were aligned with the brand artifacts and intended to establish a clear visual and conceptual framework for the rest of the site. First, the homepage was designed to act as a template, defining reusable patterns, graphics, and core design systems, including the typography choices of Bree Serif and Poppins and the newly established color palette that reflects the Upstate Underdog Rescue brand. Next, the page introduces the organization's identity and voice by opening with the phrase "Every Dog Has A Superpower," a motto frequently used in the organization's vocabulary, alongside photos pulled from their social media to immediately create warmth, familiarity, and emotional connection. The page then prioritizes clarity and accessibility for new users through the "Get Involved" section, which quickly summarizes the organization's mission and impact, followed by four clear navigation buttons that guide visitors to key actions: adoption, upcoming underdogs, donations, and volunteering. Finally, the homepage establishes consistency across the site through a unified navigation bar and footer design, which includes contact information, social media links, and their partnership with Best Friends Animal Society, reinforcing trust, credibility, and ease of navigation while setting the foundation for all subsequent pages.

The About page was designed to introduce Upstate Underdog Rescue (UUR) as an organization while establishing trust, shared values, and a sense of community among prospective adopters, donors, and volunteers. Research conducted during the Discover and

Define stages revealed that users engaging with rescue organizations often prioritize ethical alignment and emotional connection before committing to deeper interaction. As a result, the About page emphasizes mission, philosophy, and motivation over procedural or transactional information. The page opens with a clearly defined mission statement that communicates UUR's focus on at-risk shelter dogs in the Capital Region of New York State. Positioning this content at the top of the page ensures that users immediately understand the organization's purpose, reducing ambiguity and supporting quick mental model formation. This decision was informed by user stories showing that first-time adopters and donors often evaluate rescues based on values and long-term intentions rather than specific dogs or services. The language highlights patience, support, and lasting relationships, framing adoption as a deliberate and empathetic process. Following the mission, the "What We Do" section translates UUR's values into concrete actions. This section provides clarity on how the organization supports dogs and adopters, using imagery and concise descriptions to reinforce credibility without overwhelming users. Presenting this information visually aligns with usability principles of recognition over recall and allows users with varying levels of familiarity to quickly understand UUR's role. This section also supports multiple user personas by demonstrating

The Donate page was designed to make it easy for users to understand how to help Upstate Underdog Rescue and to feel confident about donating. Instead of adding extra features or complicated page elements, the design follows common donation layouts used by well-established animal rescue organizations, based on our comparative analysis. A large "Donate Now" heading and clear opening section immediately communicate the purpose of the page. This choice was made to avoid confusion and help users quickly understand what action

they are being encouraged to take. Our comparative analysis showed that pages with clear, direct messaging reduce hesitation and make users more likely to donate.

Different ways to donate are presented in a simple, card-based layout under the “More Ways to Help” section. Options such as one-time donations, monthly giving, Amazon wishlists, and in-kind donations are visually separated so users are not overwhelmed while still being able to choose the option that best fits their situation. This layout allows users to scan the page easily and make a decision without needing to read large blocks of text. Color and contrast were used to clearly separate sections and highlight donation options without distracting from the content. Buttons and headings stand out enough to guide users toward action, while the amount of text is kept brief to maintain emotional engagement and avoid information overload.

Overall, the Donate page focuses on clarity, ease of use, and emotional connection, presenting donation as a simple and meaningful action rather than a complicated process. These design decisions will later be evaluated using A/B testing, AI sentiment analysis, and survey responses to determine how effectively the page supports donation intent.

For the Adopt page, the team focused on creating a calm, intuitive experience that helps users explore adoptable underdogs with confidence and ease. Rather than overwhelming visitors with dense information or complex navigation, the page follows a familiar adoption layout commonly used by established rescue organizations, allowing users to immediately understand how to engage. The page opens with a large image of an adoptable underdog paired with a brief explanation of Upstate Underdog Rescue’s role in preparing at-risk shelter dogs for their forever homes. This opening establishes trust and sets clear expectations for the adoption process, while a prominent navigation button directs users to a Google Form where they can express interest in adopting.

Adoptable dogs are then presented in a clean, grid-based layout that prioritizes visual exploration and storytelling. Each underdog is introduced through imagery that reveals the dog's name on hover, encouraging interaction without cluttering the page. Selecting a dog leads users to a dedicated profile page, where photos, concise narrative descriptions, and key information such as the dog's assigned "superpower" and vital statistics which help bring each dog's personality to life. This structure allows users to learn about individual dogs at their own pace while maintaining a clear path forward. Finally, the page reinforces accessibility and follow-through by including a secondary call to action at the bottom, guiding users to contact the organization or submit an adoption request, ensuring the transition from interest to action feels seamless and supported.

Deliver

The Deliver stage of the Double Diamond was defined by refining implementations through empirical methods, typically involving third-party verification. The purpose of this was to pass design choices to test groups simulating users in ability and motivation. This was accomplished through Usability Testing and A/B Testing. The second goal of the Deliver stage was to clean up the product. The AI Sentiment Analysis ensured the product was sensible from a user and design perspective, caught any obvious errors, and provided possible improvement in soft areas. When AI Sentiment Analysis was conducted, the team analysed the results and interpreted their findings. Each point was debated and considered to determine if the AI was giving sensible advice. The population was RPI students, which had to be acknowledged as a bias sample. Measured statistics were (the measured statistics from the google form).

When the A/B Testing happened, the team had data on how valuable the site changes were. The population again was RPI students, which had to be acknowledged as a bias sample. Measured statistics were (the measured statistics from the google form). In this section, the team discussed how effective the design changes were in terms of the testing.

AI Sentiment Analysis

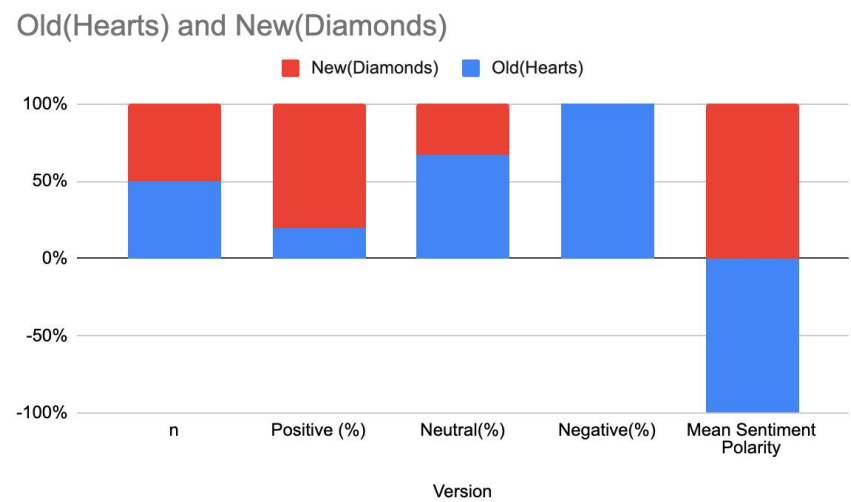
Open-ended survey responses describing participants' experiences were analyzed using an AI-based sentiment analysis tool. Responses were classified into positive, neutral, or negative sentiment categories and assigned polarity scores. Sentiment distributions were compared between the old and new versions.

Version	n	Positive	Neutral	Negative	Mean Sentiment Polarity
Old(Hearts)	5	1 (20%)	2 (40%)	2 (40%)	-0.20
New(Diamonds)	5	4 (80%)	1 (20%)	0 (0%)	0.80

Result Interpretation

The redesigned website (Diamonds) elicited substantially more positive emotional sentiment than the original website (Hearts). Participants interacting with the redesigned site frequently described the experience as intuitive, smooth, visually appealing, and easy to navigate, resulting in a strongly positive mean sentiment polarity (+0.80). In contrast, responses to the original site exhibited a more mixed and often negative emotional tone, with participants commonly reporting confusion, excessive text density, unclear purpose, and outdated design, yielding a slightly negative mean sentiment polarity (−0.20). Overall, the sentiment analysis indicates that the

redesign significantly improved users’ emotional responses and reduced frustration compared to



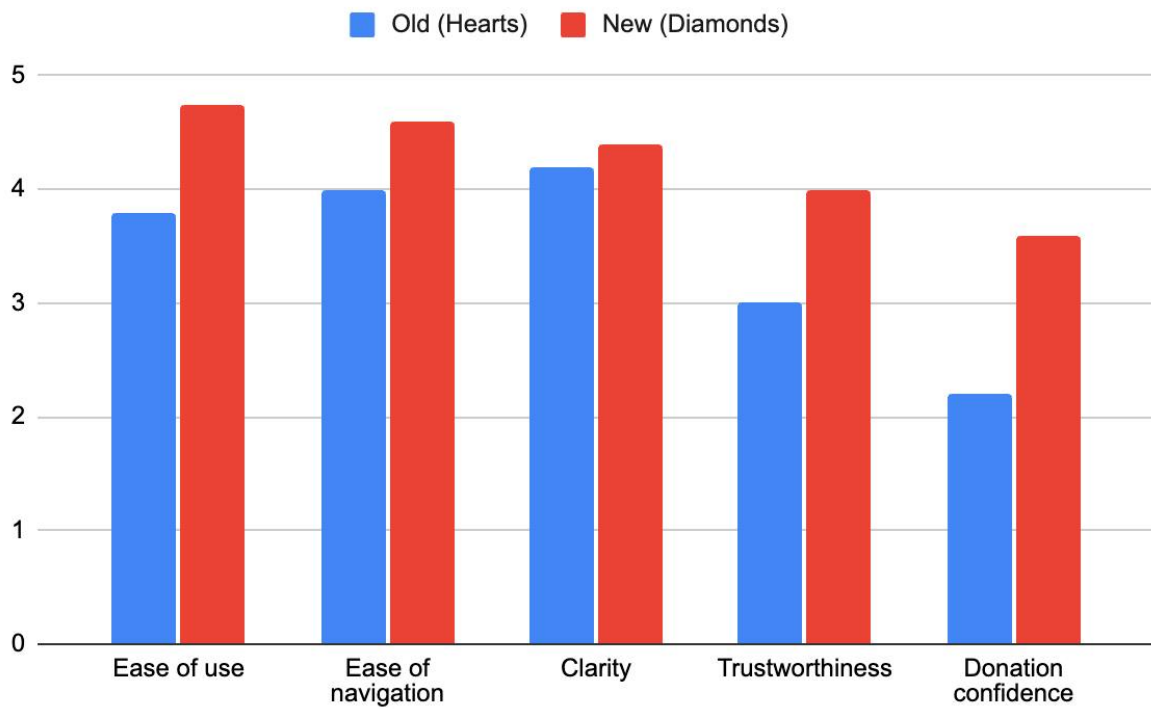
the original site.

Quantitative UX Ratings (Likert Scales)

Participants rated usability dimensions using 5-point Likert scales, including ease of use, ease of navigation, clarity of information, trustworthiness, and confidence in donating. Mean ratings were calculated for each version.

Mean Usability Ratings (1–5)

Metric	Old (Hearts)	New (Diamonds)	Direction
Ease of use	3.80	4.75	↑ New
Ease of navigation	4.00	4.60	↑ New
Clarity	4.20	4.40	↑ New
Trustworthiness	3.00	4.00	↑ New
Donation confidence	2.20	3.60	↑ New



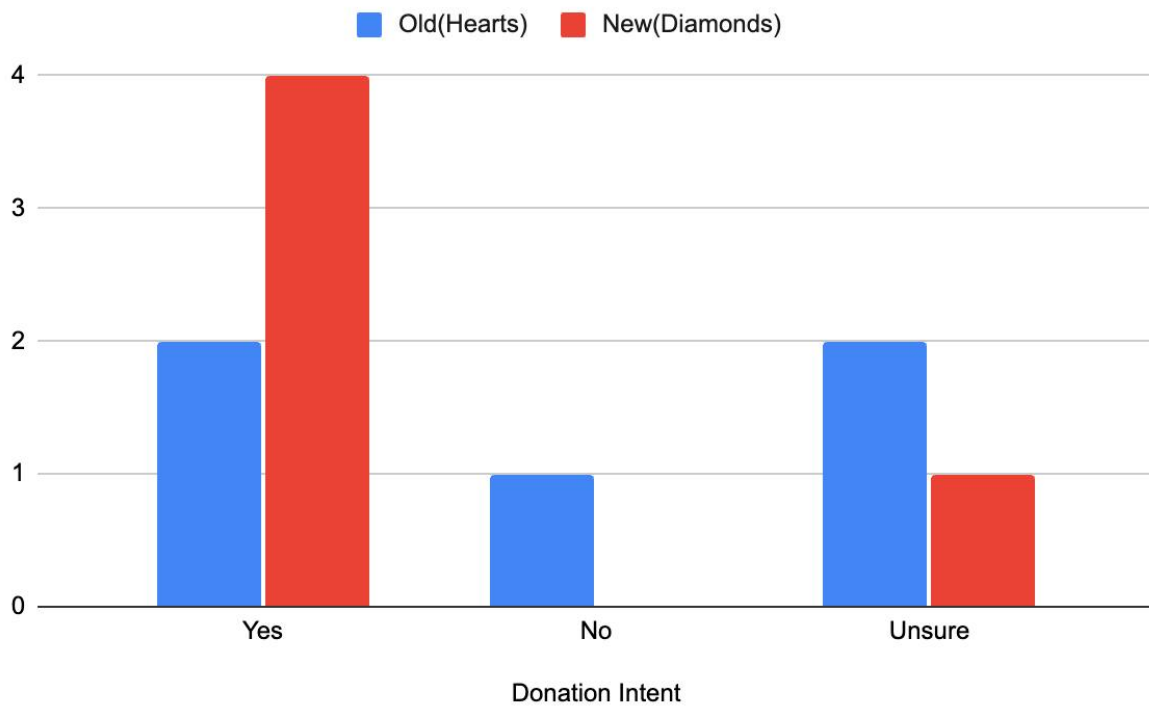
Result Interpretation

The new site (Diamonds) outperformed the old site across all usability and trust-related metrics, with the largest gains in trustworthiness and confidence to donate.

A/B Comparison: Donation Intent

Donation Intent Outcomes

Version	Yes	No	Unsure
Old(Hearts)	2	1	2
New(Diamonds)	4	0	1



Result Interpretation

Participants viewing the new site (Diamonds) were more likely to report willingness to donate and expressed significantly higher donation confidence.

Qualitative Thematic Analysis

Open-ended responses were manually coded into recurring themes to contextualize sentiment and usability ratings and explain observed differences between versions.

Theme	Old (Hearts)	New (Diamonds)
Easy navigation	3	4
Visual design / aesthetics	2	4

Confusion / clutter	2	2
Donation flow / CTA	3	1
Emotional reaction / mission	2	2

Interpretation

Comments about visual polish and layout clarity appeared more frequently in the redesigned site, while the old site prompted more discussion around donation flow mechanics, suggesting that the redesign reduced the cognitive effort required to understand next steps

Discussion

The redesigned website (Diamonds) demonstrated clear improvements in overall user experience compared to the original site (Hearts). Quantitative UX ratings showed consistently higher scores for ease of use, navigation clarity, trustworthiness, and confidence in donating, indicating that the redesign successfully improved functional clarity and perceived credibility. These findings were reinforced by higher reported donation intent among participants who viewed the redesigned site, suggesting increased conversion readiness.

AI sentiment analysis of open-ended feedback further supported these results, revealing a strong positive shift in emotional tone for the redesigned site. Participants frequently described the new design as intuitive, smooth, and visually engaging, while feedback on the original site more often referenced confusion, excessive text density, unclear purpose, and outdated design elements.

Taken together, these results suggest that the redesign improved both emotional perception and trust two critical factors for effective nonprofit engagement.

Limitations

This study faced several limitations that should be considered when interpreting the results. Although task-based usability testing was initially planned, it was ultimately excluded from the final analysis due to issues arising from unmoderated data collection. Because participants completed the task remotely without in-person guidance or monitoring, task timing data was inconsistent and unreliable. Some participants continued timing beyond the intended task, others estimated completion time rather than measuring it, and several participants exceeded the task scope by completing additional actions. As a result, task-based usability metrics varied widely and could not be used as valid performance measures.

Sample size further constrained the usefulness of task-based data. With only five participants per condition, a small number of improperly completed task responses significantly skewed the results. Only a subset of participants followed the task instructions as intended, which was insufficient for meaningful quantitative comparison. While task completion success could be observed descriptively, the limited and inconsistent timing data did not support reliable analysis. Future studies would benefit from a larger participant pool and moderated usability testing to ensure standardized task execution.

An additional limitation relates to the study's reliance on self-reported measures. Sentiment analysis, usability ratings, and donation intent were all derived from participant

feedback rather than observed real-world behavior. Although triangulation across multiple methods strengthened confidence in the findings, self-reported data may not fully reflect actual donation behavior in a live environment. Future research can incorporate behavioral analytics or live A/B deployment to validate these findings under real usage conditions.

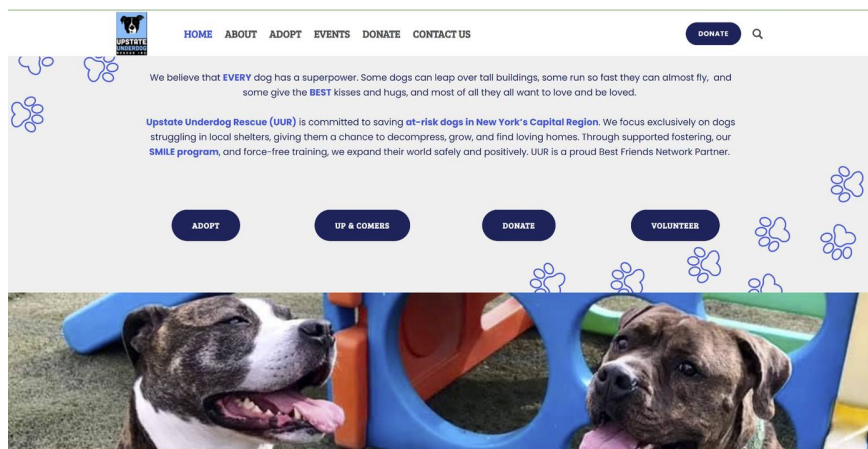
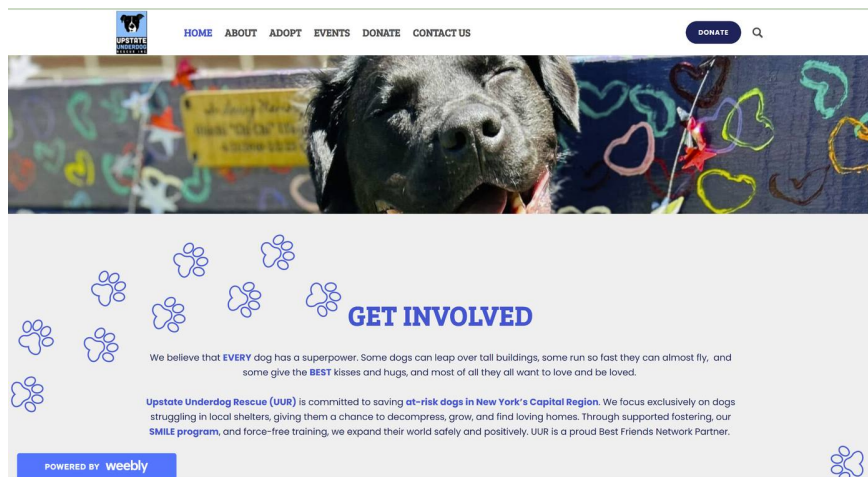
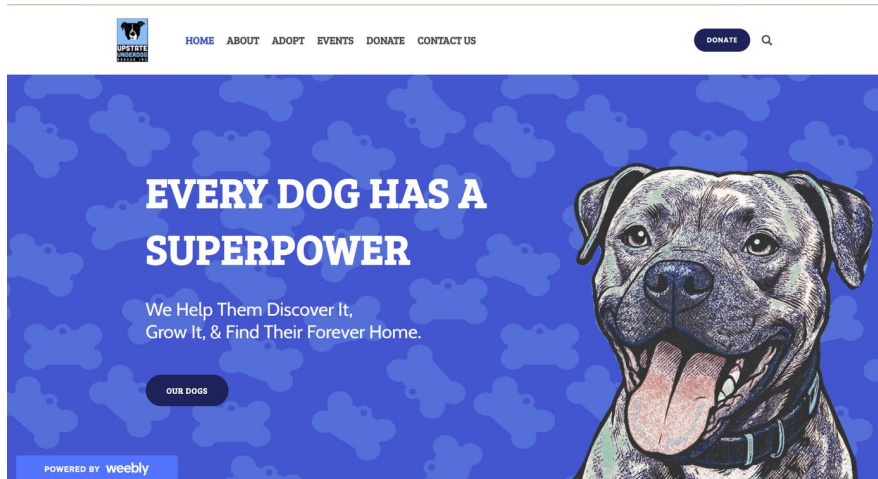
Research Conclusion

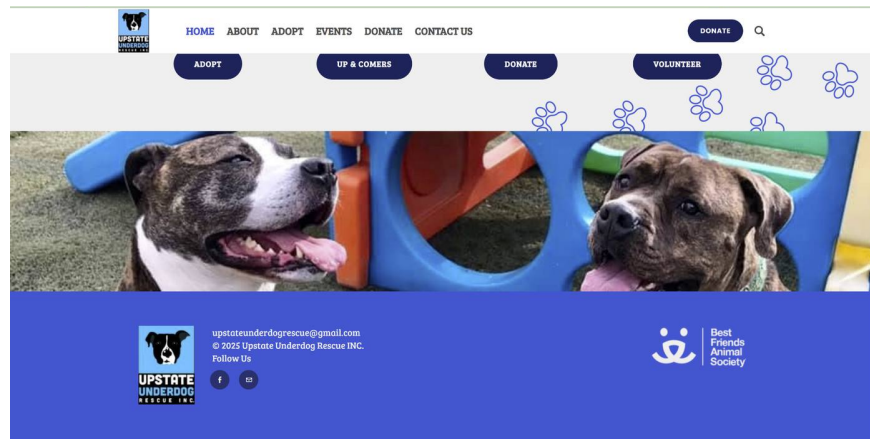
This study demonstrates the value of structured UX research and evidence-based design in improving an existing nonprofit website. By applying the Double Diamond framework, the team was able to systematically explore user needs, define key usability challenges, and iteratively evaluate design solutions using multiple complementary research methods. This approach enabled the team to ground design decisions in user feedback rather than intuition alone.

The combination of AI sentiment analysis, quantitative UX ratings, and A/B comparison provided a multidimensional assessment of the redesign's effectiveness. Results indicate that aligning emotional appeal with functional clarity and trust signals is especially important in nonprofit contexts, where user confidence directly influences engagement and donation behavior. Overall, this research highlights how disciplined UX methodologies can lead to more intuitive, credible, and conversion-oriented digital experiences.

Site Walkthrough (<https://upstateunderdog.weebly.com/>)

Home Page

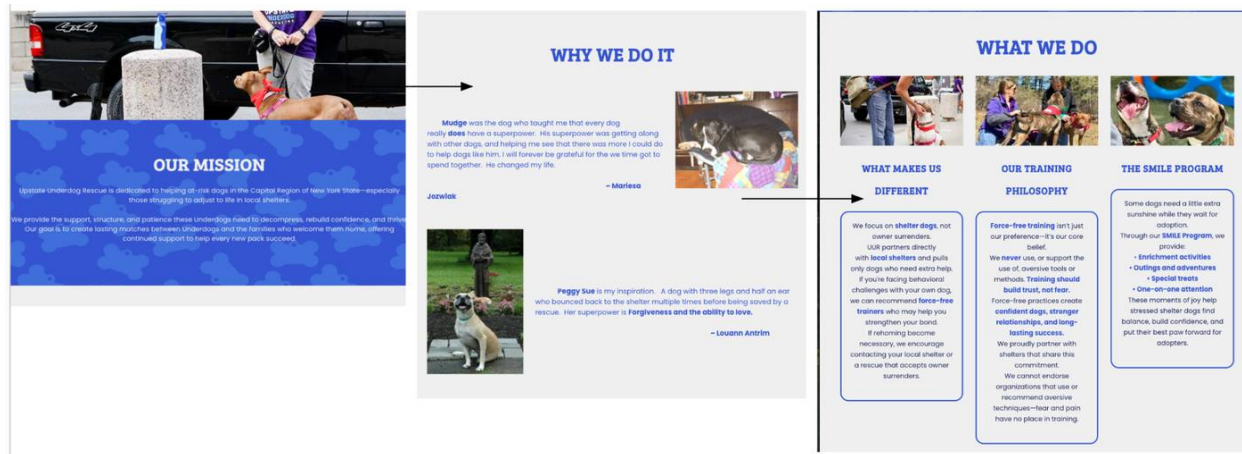




When a user arrives on the homepage, they are immediately welcomed with a clear, confident message that communicates the heart of Upstate Underdog Rescue. The page feels intentional, friendly, and easy to navigate, allowing visitors to understand the mission, connect emotionally with the dogs, and take action without feeling overwhelmed or confused. The user's experience begins with a bold headline, "Every Dog Has A Superpower" that is then paired with expressive dog imagery and a consistent brand color palette. This section instantly establishes trust and emotional connection, helping the user understand what the organization stands for within seconds. The large typography and clean layout make the message easy to read and memorable, creating a strong first impression that invites the user to continue scrolling. As the user explores the page, the navigation bar provides a clear sense of orientation. The logo is placed prominently, reinforcing brand identity, while the navigation links are organized and easy to understand. A clearly highlighted Donate button draws attention without overpowering the experience, allowing users who are ready to contribute to act immediately while still supporting casual browsing. Scrolling down, the user encounters a concise explanation of who Upstate Underdog Rescue is and how they help dogs in need. This section is written in a warm, approachable tone and supported by playful but subtle visual elements, making the content easy

to read and engaging. The user quickly gains confidence in the organization's mission and approach, without needing to search for background information. The homepage then clearly presents the user with four primary paths: Adopt, Up & Comers, Donate, and Volunteer. These buttons act as clear signposts, allowing users to choose how they want to engage based on their interests. The consistent button design and spacing reduce decision fatigue and make the site feel intuitive, especially for users unfamiliar with the organization. Throughout the homepage, real images of underdogs create moments of emotional connection that keep users engaged. Seeing the dogs early in the experience helps users feel personally invested before navigating to detailed profiles. This approach makes the organization feel transparent, caring, and dog-centered, rather than abstract or transactional. At the bottom of the page, the user finds a clean, well-structured footer that reinforces credibility and accessibility. Contact information, social media links, and partner recognition are easy to locate, allowing users to continue engaging beyond the website. The consistent branding and layout provide a polished conclusion to the homepage experience.

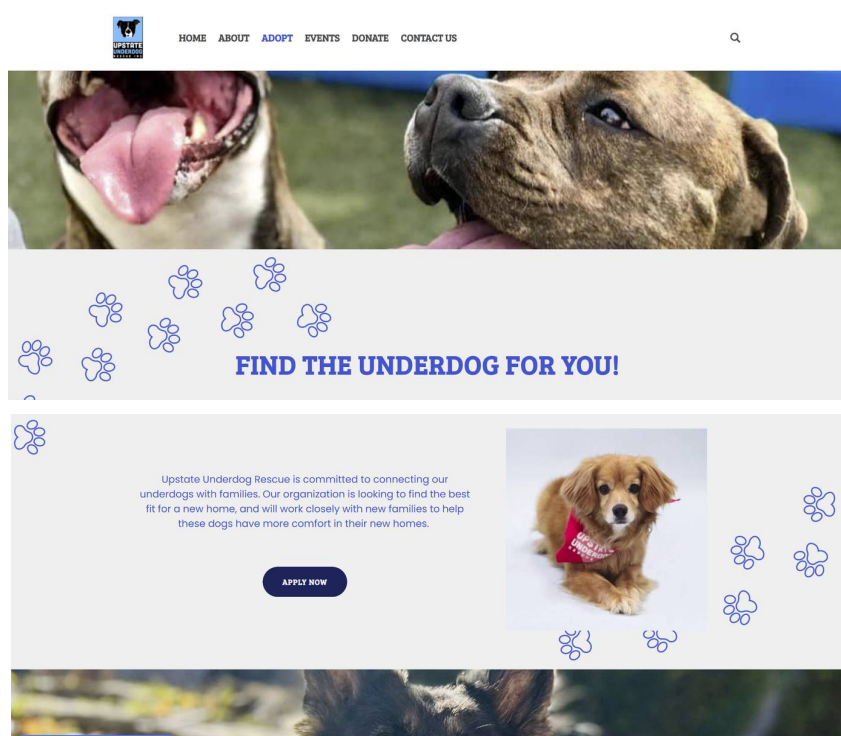
About

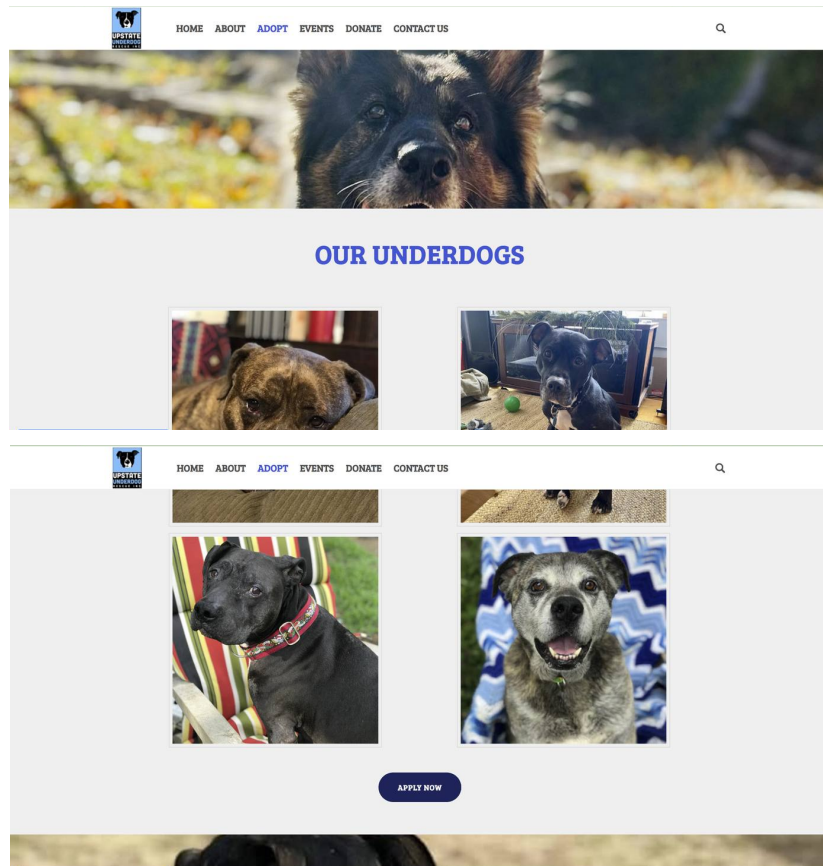


The About page is designed as a single, vertically scrolling layout that presents the organization's mission, motivation, and programs within one continuous narrative. Rather than separating this information across multiple pages, the layout allows users to move seamlessly through content by scrolling, reducing navigation effort and maintaining engagement. The page begins with a prominent mission section featuring a large hero image and a concise mission statement, immediately establishing the organization's purpose and setting an emotional tone.

As users scroll, the page transitions into a storytelling section titled "Why We Do It," which pairs short testimonials with images of dogs to humanize the organization's work and build emotional trust. The final section, "What We Do," presents the organization's programs and values in clearly defined content blocks, allowing users to quickly understand key initiatives such as training philosophy and enrichment programs. Visual separation between sections through spacing and background changes helps maintain clarity while preserving a cohesive flow across the page.

Adopt

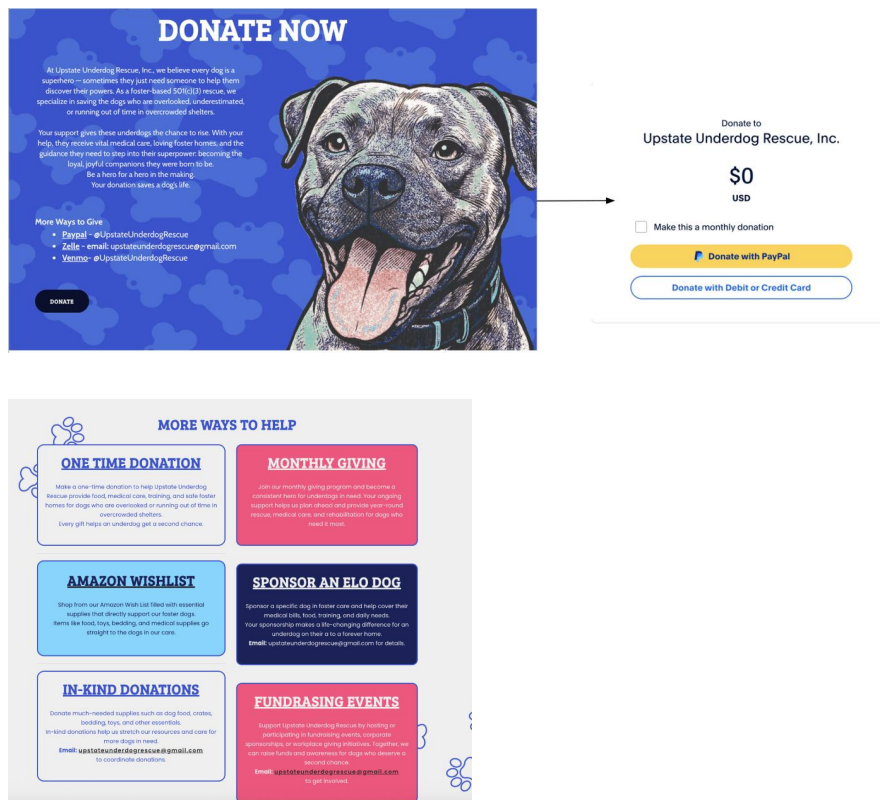




When a user arrives on the Adopt page, they are welcomed into a calm, organized experience focused entirely on the dogs. The layout makes the adoption process feel clear and approachable, allowing users to explore underdogs at their own pace without feeling overwhelmed. A strong visual hierarchy and familiar adoption layout commonly used by established rescue organizations that help guide users confidently throughout the page. The page opens with a large image of an adoptable underdog and a brief explanation of Upstate Underdog Rescue's mission to prepare at-risk shelter dogs for their forever homes. This introduction highlights care and long-term placement, while a clear button links to a Google Form where users can express interest in adopting. As users scroll, they encounter a grid of current adoptable underdogs designed for easy visual browsing. Hovering over each image reveals the dog's name, encouraging interaction while keeping the page clean and uncluttered. Clicking on a dog leads to an individual profile

page with photos, a short narrative description, vital statistics, and the dog’s assigned “superpower,” helping users connect emotionally while still learning essential information. Throughout the page, clear navigation buttons guide users toward applying or requesting more information. Overall, the Adopt page combines emotional connection with clarity and usability, guiding users smoothly from initial interest to taking the next step toward adoption.

Donate

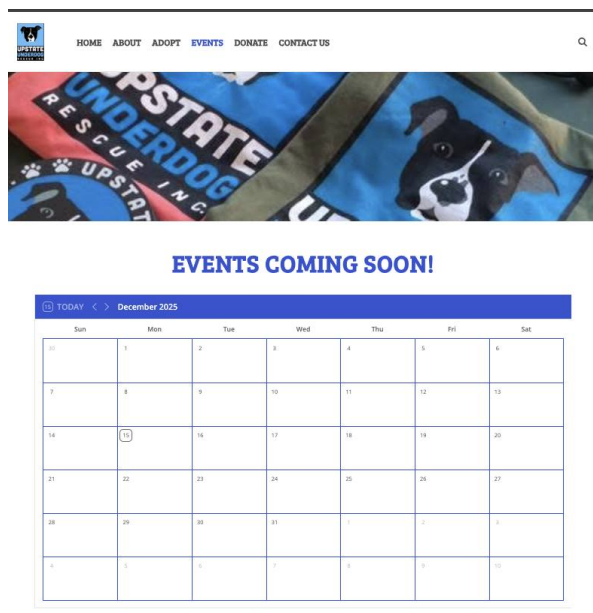


When users arrive on the Donate page, they are immediately presented with a clear call to action that communicates the page’s purpose without requiring additional navigation. The introductory section provides a brief explanation of Upstate Underdog Rescue’s mission, reinforcing emotional connection while maintaining focus on donation. Scrolling down the page reveals the “More Ways to Help” section, where users can explore multiple donation options depending on

their level of commitment and preferred method of giving. Each option is visually grouped and clearly labeled, allowing users to quickly scan and select an action without confusion or excessive decision-making.

For users interested in recurring support, the monthly giving option is emphasized as a sustained way to contribute, while alternative methods such as Amazon wishlists and in-kind donations ensure inclusivity for users who may not be able to donate monetarily. Contact information is consistently available, reinforcing transparency and trust. The page flow is designed to minimize friction by keeping interactions straightforward and predictable. Users can complete their chosen action without being redirected through unnecessary steps, supporting a smooth and emotionally supportive donation experience aligned with the goals of a rescue organization.

Events



The Events page is structured around a simple, calendar-centered layout intended to clearly communicate upcoming organizational activities while remaining functional during periods with

few or no events. The page opens with a branded header image and a clear title indicating the status of events, which helps manage user expectations and prevents confusion. This introductory section establishes context before users interact with the calendar.

Below the header, an embedded monthly calendar serves as the primary interactive element of the page. The calendar highlights the current date and allows users to navigate between months, providing a familiar and intuitive method for discovering events. When no events are scheduled, the calendar remains visible alongside messaging that reassures users that future events will be added, ensuring the page appears complete and purposeful rather than empty or unfinished.